

Manual volume automation gives even more control. During important speech, lower the music until you stop consciously noticing it. Test through ordinary earbuds and phone speakers, not only studio headphones.

Mix before you master

Mixing balances the elements inside the episode. Mastering prepares that finished mix for distribution.

Before mastering, play the programme from beginning to end and check:

- Are host and guest voices similarly comfortable?
- Does music enter and leave smoothly?
- Are inserted clips noticeably louder or quieter?
- Is there any sudden silence caused by an overly aggressive gate?
- Do edits create clicks?
- Does stereo positioning make sense?

Export a high-quality master before making compressed delivery versions. Keep this archival master even after the episode is published.

Understand loudness, not just peak level

Peak normalisation and loudness normalisation are different. Peak normalisation moves audio according to its highest sample. Loudness normalisation considers perceived programme loudness over time.



That distinction matters because two files can share the same maximum peak while one sounds substantially louder.

Adobe's podcast guidance places podcast target loudness roughly between -20 and -16 LUFS and provides tools for measuring and matching loudness. Audacity's Loudness Normalization uses perceived-loudness measurement based on EBU R128 recommendations.

For a beginner, a sensible workflow is to choose one loudness target for the entire show and use it consistently rather than chasing maximum volume. Around -16 to -18 LUFS is a

practical starting range for spoken-word podcasts, followed by a true-peak limiter to retain headroom.

Do not master by eyesight. Measure loudness, then listen again.

Export the final file correctly

Keep an uncompressed WAV master, then create the compressed file required by your podcast host.

Apple Podcasts currently accepts MP3 or AAC for RSS-fed audio. At 44.1 or 48kHz, Apple recommends 64–128kbps for mono and 128–256kbps for stereo. Apple also recommends AAC over MP3 for efficient streaming at comparable settings.

For a straightforward spoken-word show with no meaningful stereo information, mono can reduce file size. Programmes containing stereo music, spatial ambience or intentional left-right information should preserve stereo.

Export, then reopen the exported file. Do not assume that because the project sounded correct, the encoded file does too.

Generate and correct the transcript

Transcripts improve accessibility and give you searchable text for show notes, quotations and promotional material. Automated transcription can dramatically reduce typing, but it still requires human checking.

Correct names, companies, technical terms, Indian place names, code-switching, numbers and punctuation. Listen again wherever the transcript seems uncertain.

Apple Podcasts allows creators who provide their own transcripts to use VTT or SRT files and requires those transcripts to include all episode segments and be free of spelling and punctuation errors. Apple also notes that heavy cross-talk or loud music can make transcription more difficult.

Final task

Take the two-minute recording created in Chapter 4 and turn it into a finished mini-episode.

First make an editorial cut. Then remove only distracting noise, apply gentle EQ, control excessive dynamics with compression, correct obvious sibilance, and balance every speaker. Add a short music introduction if you have licensed material, fade it beneath the voice, and finish with loudness normalisation.

Export an archival WAV and a distribution-ready MP3 or AAC file. Generate a transcript and correct it while listening to the final export.

Finally, compare the untreated recording with the master on headphones and a phone speaker. The goal is not to make the edited version sound dramatically processed. It should simply sound clearer, steadier and easier to listen to.

That is successful podcast editing: not showing the listener how many tools you used, but removing every unnecessary reason for them to stop listening. 